AIRCAT-2512 Dissection

The idea of the AIRCAT series is to prepare you for all likely and some random/extreme variations in the exam, so that you are very well prepared for the more likely scenarios and prepared better-than-others for an unexpected exam. It is in this light, that a few deviations from the normal question types in VARC were an opportunity for you to adapt and get ahead of most others.

The AIRCAT series, how best you can use it and the likely impact of the same on your approach and preparation, is regularly shared with you on mails/via write-ups and YouTube videos by Deekshant sir, and various other mentors keep sharing their views and inputs. It is important for you to pick out things that are most relevant to you as an individual, as exactly the same set of things is unlikely to be equally effective for everyone. You should be looking at mocks as nothing more than practice matches, with the intent to improve between every two tests/matches.

Before initiating the dissection, here's a word of advice: There are several test series available to a student from various coaching institutes. Some variety in tests does not do any harm as long as you are not going overboard in the total number of mocks. Also, a good test series has to ADAPT to the changes, and reflect not only the most recent but also the likely future trends of the CAT. When some institutes treat it as a marketing strategy, unfortunately, it's the students who lose out. So many of our students who took more than one test series last year shared emphatically how they found the AIRCAT series both challenging and most relevant.

The variations in degree of difficulty of sections/overall tests are deliberately designed to help you prepare for all likely and possible variations in the CAT. Our team of mentors, who prepare the AIRCATs, appear for CAT every year, and the year-to-year changes in AIRCATs are carried out basis the detailed inputs from many of them.

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The test had 3 sections with sectional time limits of 40 minutes each - in effect, you are taking 3 separate tests without any breaks in between. This also means you don't have to worry about optimizing time distribution across various sections.

Each MCQ carried 3 marks for the right answer, and –1 for each wrong answer. Non MCQs did not carry negative marks, as has been the case in CAT. Students often believe that only 33% negative marking gives them the freedom to mark choices even when they are not sure. However, you must keep in mind that while the negative marking is only 33%, there is also a **75% probability of getting an answer wrong** and only a 25% chance of getting it right, when you simply guess it! So, the odds are heavily against this strategy being successful. At the same time, if you have answered say 10-12 out of the 22-odd questions in a section with relative certainty of their correctness, it may be worthwhile to make intelligent guesses (if you can narrow down to 2 options) in about 3-4 questions.

That is more likely to work as a strategy as opposed to random guesswork.

The non-MCQ questions are intended to reduce guess-work. It also means you actually have to solve questions and cannot rely on the smart use of options to shorten your path to getting to the answer. The no-negative marks scheme for such questions means that you should have still put some intelligent guesses as the answers

to these questions, for those questions that you had not been able to really solve in the conventional step-wise manner, either due to a paucity of time or lack of knowledge.

Let us now look at a detailed sectional analysis in terms of (relative) difficulty level:

	Easy	Intermediate	Difficult	Difficulty Level	Cut off Questions (Marks)
Section I (VRC)	5	12	7	Easy to Intermediate	14 (27)
Section II (DILR)	6	7	9	Intermediate to Difficult	9 (16)
Section III (QA)	9	7	6	Easy to Intermediate	12 (23)
Overall	20	26	22	Intermediate	35 (69)

Overall, the difficulty level of the 3 sections was significantly different, with DILR being the toughest section, in relative terms, although it too was easier than what you would have experienced in some of the other AIRCATs. QA was the easiest of the three sections, as can be seen from the higher percentage of easy questions. However, as expected, the scores in QA are unlikely to be far higher than those in VARC for most of you, simply because of the draining DILR section in the middle.

2 hours of peak concentration levels are still worth building as that stamina would ensure you finish QA strong even as many others begin to lose the battle through exhaustion, mental and physical. In any test, adaptability to the test type is much more important and attempting the easy to intermediate question types with 80-85% accuracy should be a priority. Had you been able to pick out the easy and intermediate ones in any section, getting to the desired cut-off levels would not have been an issue, as you can see from the table above. The sectional analysis follows.

SECTION I: Verbal Ability & Reading Comprehension (VRC)

This, though not the toughest of the 3 sections, had fewer than usual RC based questions. There is generally a tendency to over-attempt in the language section, and questions requiring RC skills are can often be overwhelming. While the first passage (about role and place of women) seemed tough to comprehend because of the nature of language used and the peculiar sentence constructions, it had relatively easy questions following it. However, the language itself would have ruled it out for most of you, whereas the scores would likely have been higher in case you attempted it. The second passage (about democracy and Zakaria) was relatively tough and avoidable, whereas the next one (about fishing) was doable. The 4th passage was shorter but had 3 questions following it, as opposed to 4 for each of the previous 3 passages.

The 2-questions based on given grammatical definitions and usage were relatively simple. While the para-jumbles were tough if you tried to save time, and the Out of Context ones were tricky, the para-summary questions would have provided solace to most of you at the end.

The challenge in VRC is to ensure an accuracy of 75% or more. This can be seen from the fact that while the average number of attempts in this section for the sample was around 20 (almost 30% higher than that in QA), the average score in this section similar to that in the QA section.

The overall attempts should have been around 15, even with say 3-4 incorrect, allowing you to pull off a score of around 30, a score good enough to put you in the top 3-4%ile in this section.

SECTION II: Data Interpretation & Logical Reasoning (DILR)

Identifying easy sets in this section would have been the crucial thing. While the first set about days and matches in IFL appeared complex, it would have proved far less time consuming than the second one (the one about Gold Certificates and Gift Vouchers) that most would have gone for, because the latter appeared simpler. The next set about phones and specifications was both tough and time consuming and best avoided. The one about IPSC Football tournament was simple but made complicated by some cases that would not have struck your mind immediately. The last set of questions (about metros and percentage breakup) was very doable - also, it is one question set, the variations of which have appeared in CAT multiple times over the years. It is a type you must be very comfortable with.

If DILR is not your forte, you could have simply aimed to clear the cut-off from about 9 questions with not more than 3 wrong.

SECTION III: Quantitative Ability (QA)

The QA section was overall 'easy to intermediate', even though some easy (non-MCQs) questions weren't so easy because of the absence of options. A good knowledge of topics you are good at would have helped immensely in cracking this part of the test.

A good score would have been around 30 (achievable with 15 attempts and 3-4 wrong) and cut-off score would be around 22-23 in this section.

Summary:

Overall a score of around 67-68 would mean a position around the 97%ile, in this AIRCAT. The past experience has shown that you can usually add between 1-2%ile for high scorers and 4-5 %ile for others to the AIRCAT %iles to get the approximate %ile in actual CAT.

A person getting between 75%ile- 90%ile in AIRCAT can expect around 4-5%ile higher. Those around 60%ile can expect a higher increase than even 5%ile.

Tentative sectional and overall benchmarks are given below:

	98%ile	95%ile	90%ile	85%ile
Section I (VRC)	35	30	26	23
Section II (DILR)	23	18	15	12
Section III (QA)	31	26	21	19
Overall	76	62	55	48

Disclaimer: The above analysis is *generic* and cannot factor in your individual strengths and weaknesses beyond a point and hence please interpret it to suit your specific Adaptability!

-AIRCAT Spinner Team (AST)